

The Westminster Kennel Club Dog Show, the ‘Super Bowl’ of Dog Shows

At America’s 149th Westminster Kennel Club dog show, Monty the giant schnauzer won the top prize.

The lively schnauzer beat six other finalists in New York City to become the first of his breed to win Westminster’s “best in show.” The prize is the most important and respected in the U.S. dog show world.

Dogs arrive for the the best in show competition during the 149th Westminster Kennel Club Dog show, February 11, 2025, in New York. (AP Photo/Julia Demaree Nikhinson)

While Monty came close to winning Westminster the past two years, he fell short of the big prize. In December 2024, the dog won another big prize, the huge American Kennel Club championship.

Monty, a giant schnauzer, takes part in the best in show competition at the 148th Westminster Kennel Club dog show Tuesday, May 14, 2024, at the USTA Billie Jean King National Tennis Center in New York. (AP Photo/Julia Nikhinson)

But for dog show lovers, Westminster is considered the Super Bowl of all shows. This year the comparison is especially fitting. That is because the most respected U.S. dog competition opened on the same weekend as the Super Bowl -- the most important game in American professional football. This rare happening came after the dates of both competitions changed in recent years.

Neal, a Bichon Fris , and its handler compete in the best in show competition during the 149th Westminster Kennel Club Dog show, Tuesday, Feb. 11, 2025, in New York. (AP Photo/Julia Demaree Nikhinson)

At Westminster, dogs first compete against other members of their breed. Then, the winner of each breed goes up against other dogs within different competition “groups.” Among the groups are sporting, working, toy, and herding. Group winners then compete in the final round.

The best in show winner gets an award – a large, shiny cup called a trophy – and a place in dog-world history. The top prize, however, does not include money.

In her report on the dog show, Learning English’s Caty Weaver explains that the Westminster show dates back to 1877. It centers on the traditional purebred judging that leads to the best

in show prize. But over the last few years, the organization has added agility and obedience events open to mixed-breed dogs.

In 2024, Sage, a miniature poodle, won best in show at the 148th Westminster Kennel Club dog show.

Sage, a miniature poodle, competes with handler Kaz Hosaka in the best in show competition during the 148th Westminster Kennel Club Dog show, Tuesday, May 14, 2024, at the USTA Billie Jean King National Tennis Center in New York. (AP Photo/Julia Nikhinson)

And in 2023, a petit basset griffon Vendéen, named Buddy Holly, won best in show at Westminster. The breed he represents is known for its rabbit-hunting abilities.

Handler Janice Hays poses for photos with Buddy Holly, a petit basset griffon Vendéen, after he won best in show during the 147th Westminster Kennel Club Dog show Tuesday, May 9, 2023, at the USTA Billie Jean King National Tennis Center in New York. (AP Photo/Mary Altaffer)

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Writers for the Associated Press reported this story from New York. Anna Matteo adapted the reports for VOA Learning English.

Quiz - Top Dog Takes Westminster, the 'Super Bowl' of Dog Shows

Vocabulary

giant - adj. ที่มีขนาดใหญ่ผิดปกติหรือมีพลังมาก

finalist - n. ผู้เข้าแข่งขันในรอบชิงชนะเลิศ

breed - n. สัตว์พันธุ์หนึ่งๆ เช่น สุนัข แมว ม้า เป็นต้น

fall short (of something) - phrase. ไม่เป็นไปตามที่คาดหวังหรือไม่ถึงมาตรฐานที่กำหนดไว้

herd - v. ต้อนสัตว์หรือผู้คนเป็นกลุ่ม

agility - n. คุณภาพหรือภาวะของการสามารถเคลื่อนไหวได้อย่างรวดเร็วและคล่องแคล่ว

obedience - n. การกระทำหรือตัวอย่างของการทำตามคำสั่ง

miniature - adj. สิ่งที่เล็กกว่าปกติเมื่อเทียบกับชนิดเดียวกัน

Reading Comprehension Quiz

1. What was the main achievement of Monty the giant schnauzer at the 149th Westminster Kennel Club dog show?

A) He was a finalist.

B) He won the top prize.

- C) He represented his breed.
- D) He participated in the show.

2. How many other finalists did Monty compete against to secure his "best in show" victory?

- A) Five
- B) Six
- C) Seven
- D) Fourteen

3. What historical significance did Monty's win hold for his particular breed?

- A) It was the first time a schnauzer competed.
- B) It was the first time a giant schnauzer was a finalist.
- C) It marked the first time his breed won "best in show."
- D) It was the most important win for any schnauzer breed.

4. According to the photo caption, on what date did the 149th Westminster Kennel Club Dog show's "best in show" competition take place?

- A) May 14, 2024
- B) December 2024
- C) February 11, 2025
- D) May 9, 2023

5. How did Monty perform at Westminster in the two years immediately preceding his victory?

- A) He won "best in show" twice.
- B) He failed to qualify for the competition.
- C) He came close but did not win the top prize.
- D) He consistently placed second in his breed.

6. What other major championship did Monty win in December 2024?

- A) The Super Bowl of Dog Shows
- B) The Westminster Kennel Club Dog show
- C) The American Kennel Club championship
- D) The USTA Billie Jean King National Tennis Center competition

7. Where was the 148th Westminster Kennel Club dog show specifically held?

- A) New York City

- B) A specific park in New York
- C) The USTA Billie Jean King National Tennis Center
- D) An undisclosed location in New York

8. Why was the comparison of Westminster to the Super Bowl particularly apt *this year*?

- A) Because Monty's victory was as dramatic as a Super Bowl game.
- B) Because both events are considered equally important nationwide.
- C) Because the two major competitions occurred on the same weekend.
- D) Because Westminster introduced football-themed events.

9. What allowed the Westminster show and the Super Bowl to take place on the same weekend this year?

- A) A scheduling error that was later corrected.
- B) A deliberate decision by organizers to maximize viewership.
- C) Recent changes in the dates of both competitions.
- D) It is a common occurrence that happens annually.

10. What is the initial stage of competition for dogs at the Westminster show?

- A) They compete against dogs from different breeds in groups.
- B) They participate directly in the final round.
- C) They compete against other dogs of their own breed.
- D) They are judged based on agility and obedience.

11. Which of the following is NOT listed as a competition "group" at Westminster?

- A) Sporting
- B) Working
- C) Guarding
- D) Herding

12. What is explicitly stated as NOT being part of the "best in show" prize at Westminster?

- A) A trophy
- B) Historical recognition
- C) Money
- D) A large, shiny cup

13. The Westminster show has a long history, dating back to which year?

- A) 2025

B) 1877

C) 2024

D) 1927

14. What new types of events has the Westminster organization introduced in recent years, making them open to mixed-breed dogs?

A) Breed-specific competitions and talent shows.

B) Agility and obedience events.

C) Hunting and tracking competitions.

D) Fashion shows and beauty contests.

15. Who was the "best in show" winner at the 148th Westminster Kennel Club dog show in 2024?

A) Monty

B) Buddy Holly

C) Sage

D) Neal